Lesson 12: Reading: The Great Migration and Culture Shock

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 1: People and Places

Adapted from People and Places - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): 3.1: Reading a Textbook: The Great Migration; 3.2: Reading: Culture Shock.

In this lesson

You read two short textbook texts: a history text about the Great Migration of African Americans from the South to Northern cities, and a sociology text about culture shock. You practice reading strategies for academic texts: skimming, reading again, taking notes and writing a one-sentence summary.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Skim a textbook text for the main idea, and then read it again for details.
- Explain the "push" and "pull" factors of the Great Migration.
- Write a one-sentence summary of each section of a text.
- Explain what culture shock is and why it happens.
- Use new words such as migration, rural, flee, taboo, custom and adjust.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
migration (n)	the movement of a large group of people from one area to another	"... this Great Migration"
rural (adj)	in the countryside; the opposite of city	"... moved from the rural South"
factor (n)	something that causes a result	"There are 'push' and 'pull' factors for any migration."
push / pull (v)	to force away / to force toward	"African Americans were also 'pulled' to the cities by job opportunities."
flee (v), fled (past)	to escape; to run away	"For African Americans fleeing this violence ..."
racism (n)	hatred or unfair treatment of people because of their race	"African Americans still experienced intense racism."
culture shock	a feeling of confusion, doubt or nervousness in a new place, for example a foreign country	"Culture shock often happens when traveling to a new country."

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
taboo	something that is not acceptable to talk about or do	"... politics, a taboo dinner topic in Caitlin's house"
custom (n)	a usual or traditional way of behaving in a culture	"She felt overwhelmed by the new customs."
cultural norms	ways of behaving that are normal and acceptable in a culture	"We relate to others through shared cultural norms."
adjust (v)	to change so that you do better in a new situation	"Adjusting to a new culture takes time."

Rules and explanations

How to read a textbook chapter

- **Read more than once.** Academic texts are difficult. You often need several readings to understand the full meaning.
- **First reading (skim):** read quickly, in only a few minutes, for the general idea. Do not try to understand every word. Then write one thing you remember and one question you have.
- **Second reading:** read slowly. Stop after each section, answer the questions and take notes.
- **Look for definitions inside the text.** Textbooks often explain a word in parentheses: "migration (the movement of a large number of people)", "lynchings (murder by hanging)".
- **Summarize:** re-read one section, cover the text, and say the main idea out loud in one sentence. Then write that sentence.

Push and pull factors

- A **push** factor forces people away from their home (problems there).
- A **pull** factor brings people toward a new place (good things there).
- Most migrations have both. Look for both kinds in "The Great Migration".

Genre and tone

- Both texts come from textbooks, so the tone is formal. They give facts, dates, numbers and names of researchers, for example "(DuBois 1951)" and "Kalervo Oberg (1960)".
- "Overcoming Culture Shock" starts with a story about Caitlin. Then it explains the idea with research, and it ends with the end of the story. Use the glossary under the text for new words.

Practice

1. Before you read. Answer out loud (to your tutor, or record yourself). Then mark the words you know in the two Vocabulary Preview lists.

- What do you know already about the history of African Americans in the U.S.?

- When you moved to a new country or city, what pulled you there? What pushed you away from your home? (If you have not moved, think of someone you know.)
- How did you feel on your first day in a new country? Did your feelings change over time?

2. First reading. Skim "The African American 'Great Migration'" (Sections One to Four) in a few minutes. Write one thing you remember and one question you have.

3. Second reading. Read again. Stop after each section and answer.

- Section One: (a) How many African Americans moved away from the South from 1865 to 1929? (b) What is the name of this large historical movement? (c) Find the 8 cities from the paragraph on the map at the end of the chapter (or an online map). Which part of the U.S. is the South?
- Section Two: (d) What is the "push" factor that caused African Americans to leave the South? (e) How many African Americans were murdered in the South between 1865 and 1900?
- Section Three: (f) What are three "pull" factors that caused African Americans to move to Northern cities?
- Section Four: (g) What were two non-economic gains for African Americans who moved to Northern cities? (h) Why was life in the city still different (difficult) for African Americans?

4. Genre and reading strategies.

- (a) The tone of this textbook chapter is _____. (formal / informal)
- (b) In order to understand and remember the information, I read it ____ times.
- (c) I skimmed this chapter before I read it slowly. (yes / no)
- (d) Information about the Civil War is in Section ____.
- (e) The definition of the Great Migration is in Section ____.
- (f) When I take notes, it _____. (helps me understand and remember / doesn't help me understand and remember)

5. Summary writing. For each section, re-read it, cover the text, and say the main idea in one sentence. Then write it. Section One is done for you: "From 1865 to 1929, 2 million African Americans moved from the South to the North." Write sentences for Sections Two, Three and Four.

6. Discuss or write. What were the "push" and "pull" factors of the Great Migration? Are any of them similar to your own reasons for moving to your current home?

7. Vocabulary match. Do the Vocabulary Activity at the end of 3.1: match the 13 words (migration, rural, historical, factor, Civil War, slavery, racism, lynching, flee, vote, violence, push, pull) with their meanings. Cover the Key language table first.

8. Culture shock: main ideas and details. Read "Sociology in the Real World: Overcoming Culture Shock" and its glossary. Then answer. For (a), (c) and (f), choose from the options in 3.2.

- (a) What is the topic of this text?
- (b) A person would probably read this textbook chapter in a _____ class.
- (c) How does the chapter explain culture shock?
- (d) What are three different cultural norms Caitlin noticed on her first day in Spain?

- (e) How did Caitlin feel by the end of her first day?
- (f) Why do people feel culture shock?

9. Vocabulary practice. Answer the seven questions in "Vocabulary Practice" (3.2), for example "What are several examples of taboos in your culture?" and "Have you experienced culture shock? What did it feel like?" Say each answer to your tutor, then write it in a complete sentence.

Speak with your tutor

- "I will explain the push and pull factors of the Great Migration in my own words. Correct my past tense verbs."
- "I will retell Caitlin's story in five or six sentences. Check my facts and my grammar."
- "Ask me about greetings, dinner times and taboo topics in my culture. Help me use the words custom, taboo, gesture and cultural norms."

Read aloud

- mi·GRA·tion
- RU·ral
- his·TOR·i·cal
- FAC·tor
- VI·o·lence
- SLAV·er·y
- op·por·TU·ni·ties
- ta·BOO
- GES·ture
- ad·JUST

Answer key

1-2. Your own answers.

3. (a) Almost two million. (b) The Great Migration. (c) The 8 cities are in the North: in the Northeast and the Midwest. The South is the southern part of the U.S., mostly in the south-east. (d) Intense racism: groups like the Ku Klux Klan caused death threats, violence and lynchings. (e) According to researchers at the Tuskegee Institute, there were 3,500 (thirty-five hundred) lynchings and other murders. (f) Any three: job opportunities; the chance to vote (for men, at least); factory owners and other businesses helped pay for their moves; higher wages than in the South; it was easier to find housing. (g) Greater educational opportunities and personal freedom (they could move, work and speak freely). (h) The cost of living (rent and food) was higher, housing was often overcrowded and dirty, and they still experienced racism from landlords, bankers and neighbors.

4. (a) Formal. (b), (c), (f) Your own answers; the book's method is to skim first, then read slowly, two or more times. (d) Sections One and Two: One gives the year the war ended (1865); Two says it had ended and laws were passed to end slavery. (e) Section One ("as the large number of African Americans leaving the South was called"). Section Two defines the word "migration".

5. (example answer) Two: Racism and violence in the South pushed African Americans to leave. Three: Jobs, higher wages and the chance to vote pulled African Americans to Northern cities. Four: Life in Northern cities was still difficult, but African Americans found more educational opportunities and personal freedom there.

6. (example answer) The push factors were racism and violence. The pull factors were jobs, higher wages and the chance to vote. I moved to a new city for a better job, so my reason was a pull factor too.

7. The meanings, from the first to the last in the book's list, go with: 1 historical, 2 lynching, 3 migration, 4 racism, 5 rural, 6 push, 7 pull, 8 slavery, 9 factor, 10 Civil War, 11 flee, 12 vote, 13 violence.

8. (a) Culture shock. (b) Sociology (see the title, "Sociology in the Real World"). (c) By telling a story that shows what culture shock is, and showing why it happens. (d) Any three: Maria's mother kissed her on both cheeks when she greeted her; dinner was very late (10 p.m.); the family sat at the table for hours; they spoke loudly and argued about politics at dinner; they made toasts to their guest, and the guest should make the next toast. (e) She felt overwhelmed by the new customs, language and surroundings, and she wanted to go home. (f) Differences in cultural norms are hard to understand, and make people feel stressed, alone, and overwhelmed.

9. (example answers) In my culture, it is taboo to talk about money at the dinner table. When people are angry, they frown. To adjust quickly, people can learn the language, make friends and ask about local customs.

My notes